

when I was a child. There was always enough of a safety net or a bailout that I was able to rest on my laurels, and it made for a really rude awakening when I reached that breaking point, where there was no money left and I was panicking about how to pay my rent. All the while that I was moving small amounts of money from one account to another, trying to plug the ever-growing holes in my budget, I was also, somehow, thinking about which new rug would look nicest in our living room.

It's a distraction, of course, from the real situation – a form of burying one's head in the sand in order to ward off that scary acknowledgement that things might not be under your control. If there is money for a new rug, then how can there possibly be a problem? La la la, I'm not listening.

Maria* has also experienced this sort of money dysmorphia: 'I was totally in denial,' she says, 'I suppose I thought that I could juggle it and was okay as long as I had a wage coming in to pay the debt. Then, Covid hit, and I no longer had a wage – only then did I face up to things. I used to do things to try and keep up with friends, like nights out and holidays, and I'm also a single mum and have never wanted my daughter to miss out, so I always felt that I needed to get her the best of the best – clubs, extra-curricular activities etc.'

The research that Mona Chalabi references in her *Guardian* piece, a study entitled, 'The relationship between objective and subjective wealth is moderated by financial control and